Product & UX Writing

121 terms · name, then the phrase to paste · Workbook Library

Principles

Front-load the point front-load every string: the outcome or the object in the first two or three words, conditions and reasons after

Specific verbs use specific verbs that say exactly what will happen ("Send invoice", "Archive project"), never generic ones like Submit or Proceed

Everyday words use everyday words a 12-year-old would know; replace "utilize", "initiate", "prior to" and similar with use, start, before

Name it from the user's side name every setting and feature by the effect the person will notice, never by the internal system or data model

One idea per message give each message exactly one idea or one action; split or cut anything that tries to do two jobs

Cut to the useful cut every word that doesn't change what the reader does next; keep the information, lose the filler ("simply", "please note", "at this time")

Active voice, clear actor use active voice with a clear actor: "we" for the product, "you" for the reader, a name when another person did it

Say what to do phrase instructions positively, as what to do, and never use double negatives

Sentence case use sentence case for every heading, button, menu item and tab; capitalize only the first word and proper nouns

One name per thing use exactly one term for each concept and one verb for each action throughout; never alternate synonyms (e.g. always "workspace", always "sign in")

Numerals and real numbers use digits for all numbers and give exact counts and times wherever the product knows them ("Delete 12 photos", "Saved 2 minutes ago")

You, we and my address the reader as "you" and the product as "we"; don't mix "my" and "your" for the same thing

UI punctuation no periods on labels, buttons or headings; full stops on full sentences; at most one exclamation mark and only for real wins; an ellipsis on menu items that open a dialog

Dates, times and units write dates with spelled months, relative time for the last week, time zones when people are in different places, and units on every number

Contractions use common contractions (you'll, can't, we're) for a natural voice, but spell out a negative where misreading it would be costly

Descriptive link text write link text that names the destination or action and makes sense out of context; never "click here" or a bare "learn more"

Inclusive language use inclusive, input-neutral language: "select" not "click", gender-neutral pronouns, no idioms or disability metaphors, "allowlist" not "whitelist"

Localization-ready strings write strings that localize cleanly: complete sentences with named placeholders, proper plural forms (no "file(s)"), and room for 40% text expansion

Controls & labels

Button label write button labels that start with a verb and name the object ("Save draft", "Invite 3 people"), two or three words, never OK or Submit

Primary and secondary pair when two buttons sit together, label both with their outcome ("Keep editing" and "Discard changes"), never Yes/No or an ambiguous Cancel

Call to action write the call-to-action as the benefit in the reader's voice ("Start my free trial"), with the price or terms stated right under the button

Destructive action label destructive buttons with the exact verb and object ("Delete project"), style them as a warning, and state permanence in the body text

Link vs button use links for destinations (named as nouns) and buttons for actions (named as verbs); never mix the two

Menu items write menu items as short verbs in sentence case, most-used first, destructive actions last behind a divider, without repeating the object

Icon labels and accessible names give every icon-only control a tooltip and accessible name that states its action, and write alt text that says what an image means, not what it looks like

Field label write field labels as short noun phrases in the person's words, always visible above the field, without colons

Placeholder text use placeholder text only for a short "e.g." example of a good answer; never as the label or for instructions

Helper text write one line of helper text per field that answers the question a person would have before they make a mistake: format, reason or privacy

Required and optional mark only the optional fields, with "(optional)" in the label, and assume everything else is required

Inline validation write inline validation as the fix with an example ("Enter a date like 14 March 2026"), shown when the person leaves the field

Character counter show a character counter that counts remaining characters near the limit and says "N characters too long" when over, never silently truncating

Password requirements show password requirements before typing as a checklist that ticks off live, each rule written as a plain target

Form heading and intro title forms with the task in the person's words and add one line on what they'll need and how long it takes

Page titles and headings title each page with what's on it, matching the navigation label that led there, and write subheadings that make sense when scanned alone

Navigation labels write navigation labels as plain one- or two-word nouns that clearly predict what's behind them and don't overlap

Tabs and filters write tabs and filter chips as short parallel labels in the same grammatical form, with counts where they help

Settings and toggles write toggle labels as the thing being turned on or off (not a verb), each with one line describing what changes

Search placeholder write the search placeholder to say exactly what it searches ("Search files, people and comments")

Tooltip write tooltips as one short line that adds information the label can't hold, never repeating the label and never hiding essential info

States & feedback

First use write a first-use empty state: one line on what will appear here and why it's useful, and one button for the smallest first step

No results write a no-results state that repeats the search term, suggests a fix (spelling, broader terms, clearing filters) and offers to create the thing if that makes sense

Filtered to nothing write a filtered-empty state that says the filters hide everything, names the active filters, and offers a one-press "Clear filters"

All done write an "all caught up" state that lightly acknowledges the person cleared it and says when new items will appear, without pushing another task

No access write a no-access state that says the person doesn't have access, names who can grant it, and offers a "Request access" action

Not enough data yet write a "not enough data yet" state that says what's being collected and when there will be something to see

Couldn't load write a load-failure state that makes clear the data exists but didn't load, gives the reason if known, and offers "Try again"

Loading message write loading text as a present-tense verb phrase saying what's happening, plus a time estimate when it takes more than a few seconds

Progress with steps for long tasks, show the current step in plain words with a count ("Copying 1,204 of 3,500 files") alongside the progress bar

Long wait, we'll tell you for waits longer than a minute, tell the person they can leave and exactly how they'll be told when it's done

Save status write a quiet save-status line ("Saving…", "Saved", "Saved 2 minutes ago") that turns into a clear warning only when work is at risk

Skeleton screens for short loads, show skeleton placeholders with real headings and no loading text

Success toast write success toasts in the past tense, naming the object, mirroring the button that triggered them ("Invoice sent"), with no exclamation marks

Undo instead of confirm for reversible actions, skip the confirmation dialog: perform the action and show a toast with Undo

Done page write a confirmation page: say it worked, give the reference number, say what happens next and when, and offer one likely next action

Milestone moment for a real milestone, write a short celebration that names the specific achievement and suggests a next step; use it rarely

What, why, what now write every error as what happened, why (if it helps), and what to do now, in plain words, with an action button where possible

Our fault for server-side errors, say it's on our end, reassure what's safe, say when to retry, and put any error code small at the end for support

Offline write offline messages that say what still works, whether changes will sync later, and briefly confirm when the connection is back

404 page write a 404 page: say the page isn't here and why that might be, a light touch of personality, and two useful ways forward

Payment declined write payment-failure copy that's calm and private: what didn't go through, what's not affected yet, the deadline, and a one-step way to update the card

Limits and too many tries for limits and lockouts, say why the limit exists, exactly when they can try again, and any way around it now

Edit conflict write edit-conflict copy that names who changed it and when, reassures that both versions are kept, and offers clear choices

Partial failure for partial failures, lead with how many succeeded and failed, name the failed items and the reason, and offer to retry only those

System banner write a system banner that says what's affected and when in the first few words, with a link to details

Approaching a limit write a usage warning with the actual numbers, what happens at the limit, and two ways out (free up space, or upgrade)

Unsaved changes write an unsaved-changes warning that names what will be lost and offers "Save and leave", "Leave without saving" and staying

Change is coming write a change notice that says exactly what's changing, the date, what the person needs to do, and what happens if they do nothing

Onboarding & education

Welcome screen write a welcome screen with one sentence on what the product does for this person and a single first step; skip excitement and feature lists

Sign-up form write a sign-up form with the fewest possible fields, a short reason for anything unusual, the cost stated by the button, and an outcome-named button

Setup questions write setup questions that each say how the answer helps the person, are skippable, and note they can be changed later

Getting-started checklist write a getting-started checklist of 3 to 5 verb-led tasks ordered by value, with the first already done and a way to dismiss it

Sample content write labels for sample content that make it unmistakably an example and offer a one-click way to remove it

Permission priming write a pre-permission screen shown in context that explains what access is used for and what the person gets, with a "Not now" option

Coach mark write a coach mark that points at one control and says what it does and why it helps in under 20 words, with "Got it"

Product tour write a product tour of at most three steps, each teaching one non-obvious thing, with a step counter and a visible "Skip tour"

Progressive disclosure put secondary information behind expanders whose labels say exactly what's inside ("How we calculate your pace")

What's new write a feature announcement that leads with what the person can now do, where to find it, and one action to try it

Contextual nudge write a contextual nudge triggered by what the person just did, suggesting a shortcut, with a way to dismiss it for good

Help links write help links as the question the article answers ("How do shared links expire?")

Decisions & money

Confirmation dialog write a confirmation dialog only for hard-to-undo actions: the title names the action and object, the body states the consequence, the button repeats the verb

Type to confirm for irreversible, high-impact deletes, spell out exactly what will be destroyed with numbers and ask the person to type the name to confirm

Permission purpose string write the system permission purpose string as one full sentence saying specifically what the access is used for

Consent and cookies write consent copy where accept and decline are equally easy and visible, each purpose is described plainly, and nothing is pre-checked

Privacy note at collection next to any sensitive field, write a one-line privacy note saying what it's used for and who sees it

Plan comparison write plan cards named by who they're for, with full price and billing period together, only the differences listed, and an action-named button

Upgrade at the limit write an upgrade prompt that names what the person tried to do, the plan and price that includes it, and how they can continue without upgrading

Trial ending write a trial-ending reminder that states the charge date, exact amount and how to cancel in its first lines

Receipt write a receipt with the amount in the subject line and the item, date, payment method, PDF link and refund route in the body

Cancellation flow write a cancellation flow that says when access ends and what happens to the person's data, offers one alternative once, and confirms without guilt

Price change notice write a price-change notice with the old and new price, effective date, a one-line honest reason, and the options the person has

Messages & AI

Push notification write a push notification whose title makes sense alone on a lock screen and whose body adds the one detail that matters, under 100 characters

Transactional email write a transactional email with the news in the subject line, the key detail in the first sentence, and one main button

Verification and magic links write a verification message with the code in the first line, how long it's valid, and what to do if the person didn't request it

Password reset write password-reset copy that doesn't reveal whether an account exists, gives the link's expiry, and reassures people who didn't request it

Digest write a digest email that leads with what needs the person, groups the rest, links each item, and includes a frequency setting

Text message write an SMS that names the sender first, gives one fact and one action, fits in 160 characters, and includes opt-out where required

Prompt starters write 3 or 4 prompt starters that show specific things the assistant does well in this product, phrased the way a person would type them

Working state write an assistant working state that names the concrete step in progress and offers a Stop control

AI disclosure label AI-generated content close to it in neutral words and say what the person should check before using it

Sources and citations when answering from documents, mark each claim with a numbered citation that links to the source by its recognizable name, and say when no source was found

Can't do that when the assistant can't do something, say so in one line and offer the closest thing it can do, without apologizing at length

Agent action confirmation before an AI agent takes a consequential action, show exactly what it will do, to whom and with what content, and ask for approval with a specific verb button

Feedback ask write an optional feedback ask with clear labels and, after negative feedback, a few specific reasons to choose from and a note on how feedback is used

Practice

Oops and whoops avoid "Oops", "Uh-oh" and other cutesy openers in errors; say what happened instead

Something went wrong avoid generic errors like "Something went wrong"; always say what failed, what's safe and what to try

Confirmshaming never use confirmshaming; write the decline option as neutrally as the accept ("No thanks")

Click here never write "click here" or "here" as link text; link the words that describe the destination

Are you sure? never write "Are you sure?"; name the action and its consequence, or offer Undo instead of asking

Blaming words avoid blaming words like "invalid", "illegal", "failed to" and "wrong"; describe what to do instead

System words never show internal or technical terms (null, 403, sync token, payload); translate them into what the person sees and can do

False urgency never use false urgency or scarcity; state real deadlines plainly

Please and thank-you overload don't overuse "please" or "sorry"; keep them for real favors and real failures

Jokes at bad moments use humor only in low-stakes moments; keep errors involving money, data, security or health plain and calm

Content-first design start from the content: list what this screen has to say and in what order before suggesting any layout

String table return the copy as a string table with columns for key, string, where it appears, character count and notes for translators

Word list use this word list exactly; never substitute the "don't use" terms (paste your list here)

Voice chart follow this voice chart: for each trait, write like the "we are" column and never like the "we're not" column (paste your chart)

Highlighter test apply a highlighter test: keep only the words the reader needs to act, and explain what you cut

Text expansion check check each string at 140% length and with the longest realistic values, and flag any that would truncate

Comprehension test review this copy as a first-time user would: paraphrase what each message means and what you'd do next, and flag anything ambiguous

Content audit audit these strings: flag inconsistent terms, off-voice lines, missing empty/error/loading states and anything over length, then suggest fixes in a table